Few biological parameters suffice to reproduce measured dynamics in systems biology models: local sensitivity-based reduction with formal verification of the mathematical foundations

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Abstract

Mathematical models of biological processes often contain dozens to hundreds of unknown rate constants, but experimental data rarely contain enough information to estimate all of them. We present a method that, starting from published parameter values and before any new model fitting, identifies a small set of biological parameters sufficient to reproduce the measured data when only those parameters, together with the measurement scaling and offset factors, are re-estimated and all other parameters are kept at their published values. The method ranks parameters by how strongly they change the measured quantities, discards parameters whose effects are redundant, checks that the reduced model can reproduce the data under random parameter perturbations, and finally removes any parameter that is not needed. We applied it to 34 published models with real experimental data. In 32 of them a small subset was sufficient, in most cases only two biological parameters, and most subsets remained adequate for parameter changes of up to 50%; profile likelihood, an independent method, likewise found a median of two practically identifiable biological parameters per model. We compared the method with four existing selection criteria (pivoted QR, Brun's collinearity index, Morris screening and profile likelihood) choosing the same number of parameters. Many small subsets predicted held-out experiments similarly when anchored at the published values, as expected for sloppy models, but they differed in whether they actually reproduced the full model: our

subsets did so in all 29 comparable models at ±5% and in 28 at ±20% parameter changes, against 13–24 and 14–23 for the other criteria, and in a leakage-free synthetic test they reached the prediction threshold more often than pivoted QR and profile likelihood (by 20 and 15 percentage points). The number of sensitivity simulations grows linearly with model size; the complete method took from seconds to about half an hour per model, whereas profile likelihood required up to hours and was infeasible for the five largest models. The main mathematical steps of the method are verified with a computer proof assistant.

Keywords: parameter reduction, practical identifiability, sensitivity analysis, ordinary differential equations, systems biology, formal verification

Introduction

Ordinary differential equation (ODE) models are central to quantitative biology, pharmacology and epidemiology, where they describe how interacting molecular species or populations change over time as a function of kinetic parameters θ[1]. Using a model for prediction requires estimating θ from experimental measurements, and this becomes difficult as models grow. The main obstacle is non-identifiability: different parameter values may produce the same measured output, either because of model symmetries (structural non-identifiability) or because the available data are insufficient (practical non-identifiability)[2–4]. In both cases the likelihood has flat ridges on which optimisers stall and confidence intervals become unreliable[5–7]. Models in public benchmark collections routinely contain 20–300 parameters[8], and genome-scale models contain thousands[9].

The sloppy-model phenomenon offers a structural explanation[10]: the sensitivity of model outputs to parameters is typically dominated by a few "stiff" directions, while many "sloppy" directions have almost no effect on the outputs. This suggests that a small subset of parameters may suffice to describe what is actually measured. Exploiting this observation in practice requires answering three questions that existing tools address only partially. First, which parameters should be retained? Many criteria exist: global sensitivity indices[11, 12] and profile likelihoods[5, 29] rank parameters by importance or identifiability, and subset-selection methods based on the sensitivity matrix—pivoted QR[32], collinearity indices[14] and related identifiability screenings[30]—additionally avoid redundant parameters[13]. All of them return a subset, but none checks whether re-estimating that subset actually reproduces the behaviour of the full model. Second, is the reduced model good enough? A reduction is useful only if re-estimating the retained parameters reproduces the measured data and predicts experiments that were not used for fitting. Third, how much can the conclusions be trusted? Statements such as "the discarded parameters can be fixed" rest on approximations whose validity is rarely made explicit.

This work was motivated by a dynamical model of Bandura's social cognitive theory[15, 16], in which six psychosocial constructs that determine physical activity interact through 22 parameters (coupling strengths, input gains and time constants).

When all 22 parameters were estimated from 31 days of step-count data, many stable parameter sets fitted the data with widely different quality (coefficients of determination between 4% and 86%), and local refinement from the best global estimate lowered the fit from 86% to 41%[17]. Such behaviour is typical when several parameters have nearly identical effects on the measured output, so that the data cannot separate them; in such models, a principled way to decide which parameters to estimate is indispensable.

Here we present a reduction method that works directly on the measured outputs defined in the PEtab format[18], including experimental conditions, measurement transformations and noise levels. It distinguishes biological parameters, which belong to the mechanistic model, from calibration parameters (scaling factors and offsets of the measurement process), which are always re-estimated, and selects only among the biological ones. Candidates are ranked by sensitivity, redundant candidates are rejected by condition-number and variance-inflation tests, the reduced model is accepted only if re-estimating its parameters reproduces the full model under random parameter perturbations, and a final backward elimination makes the subset minimal with respect to inclusion. We evaluate the method on 34 benchmark problems with real data[8, 18], test the reduced models on held-out experiments, quantify their robustness to perturbation size and to the method's own settings, compare the selected subsets with those of four existing criteria under the same protocol, and report the computational cost of the complete method. The main mathematical statements on which the method relies are formally verified in the Lean 4 proof assistant with the Mathlib library[19, 20]; we state precisely what is and what is not proved.

Results

Overview of the method

Figure 1 summarises the procedure; all symbols are defined in the Methods and in Supplementary Table S2 (Supplementary Note *Notation of the method*). The input is a PEtab problem: an SBML model, the list of measured observables with their experimental conditions, measurement times, transformations (linear, logarithmic) and noise standard deviations σ_i, and the nominal parameter values θ_0 reported by the original authors. Each measurement i defines a scaled output $y_i(\theta) = h(g_i(x(t_i;\theta),\theta))/\sigma_i$, so that all outputs are comparable in units of measurement noise. Parameters are split into biological parameters θ_B (those of the SBML model) and calibration parameters θ_C (observation scalings and offsets); only biological parameters are candidates for selection, while calibration parameters are always re-estimated together with the selected ones.

The relative sensitivity matrix $J = \partial y/\partial \log\theta$ is computed once at θ_0 by central finite differences. In stage 1, biological parameters are added in decreasing order of their sensitivity energy $E_j = \|J_{:,j}\|^2$; a candidate is accepted only if the condition number κ and the largest variance inflation factor (VIF) of the normalised columns of J_S stay below a threshold, and is otherwise discarded permanently. Stage 1 stops when the accepted parameters capture a fraction τ_R of the total energy. The

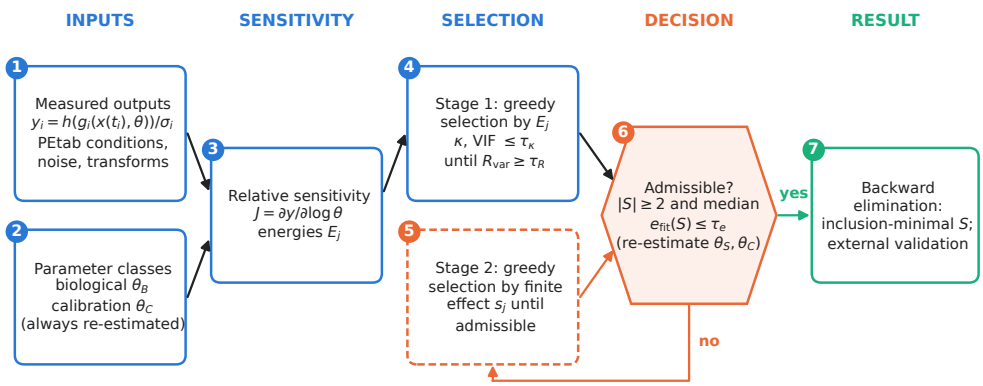


Fig. 1 Overview of the reduction method. Biological parameters are ranked by their effect on the measured outputs and selected with conditioning control (κ and VIF thresholds; stage 1, or stage 2 if needed, dashed). A subset is accepted when re-estimating it reproduces the full model; backward elimination then makes it minimal, and the reduced model is validated on held-out data.

resulting subset S is then tested: in random scenarios where all parameters are perturbed, θ_S and θ_C are re-estimated with the remaining parameters fixed at θ_0, and S is admissible if the median relative fitting error e_{fit} is below τ_e and $|S| \geq 2$. The threshold $\tau_e = \sqrt{1 - c^2}$ equals the smallest error attainable by rescaling an output change whose cosine similarity with the full change is c (Theorem 1); we use $c = 0.9$, so $\tau_e = 0.436$. If stage 1 does not yield an admissible subset, stage 2 repeats the selection with parameters ordered by their finite-perturbation effect s_j until an admissible subset is found. Finally, backward elimination removes any parameter whose removal keeps the subset admissible, which yields a subset that is minimal with respect to inclusion (Theorem 2).

A motivating case with exact collinearity

The social cognitive theory model[15–17] describes six psychosocial constructs through a linear system with 22 parameters and a single measured output (daily steps from one participant[17]). At the published estimate θ_0, the sensitivity matrix of behaviour is exactly rank-deficient (infinite condition number, maximum VIF 4.5×10^{15}), with nine pairs of parameters having cosine similarity above 0.95, making the full estimation problem ill-posed. The method selected two parameters (γ_{57} and β_{45}, the path from the external input through social satisfaction to behaviour), which, re-estimated on days 1–24, predicted the held-out week with $R^2 = 0.84$ (test χ^2/n 1.63), better than the full model refitted locally ($R^2 = 0.67$) or by differential evolution ($R^2 = 0.79$); the model is not counted in the benchmark statistics below (Supplementary Note *The social cognitive theory model*, Supplementary Table S18 and Supplementary Fig. S5).

Benchmark: a few biological parameters suffice in most models

We applied the method to 34 PEtab benchmark problems with real measurements[8, 18] covering signalling, metabolism, gene regulation, cell cycle, immunology and epidemiology, with 3 to 294 parameters and 16 to 27,132 measurements (Table 1); Supplementary Note *System-by-system summary* describes each problem, the meaning of its selected parameters and its validation. One further benchmark problem (Froehlich, 4,231 parameters and 9,169 experimental conditions) was analysed only on its state trajectories because each evaluation of its measured outputs requires about 9,000 simulations; it is not counted here (see Computational cost).

The method found an admissible subset in 32 of the 34 problems (Fig. 2 and Table 1). In 29 of them the subset contains only two biological parameters; two is also the minimum subset size enforced by the method ($k_{\min} = 2$), so this result does not imply that a single parameter would be insufficient—Supplementary Note *Single-parameter subsets* shows that one biological parameter already reaches the admissibility threshold in 16 of 27 tested problems. The remaining three subsets contain three (Zhao), five (Bruno) and ten (Lucarelli) biological parameters. Sixteen problems also have calibration parameters (up to 79 in Raimundez), which are re-estimated in every case. Counting both kinds, the reduced estimation problem has a median of 78% fewer free parameters than the full one (range 33–97%); among biological parameters alone, the median reduction is 88%. Backward elimination removed between one and five parameters in seven problems (Supplementary Note *Selected subsets of the benchmark problems*, Supplementary Table S1). All 32 subsets satisfy the conditioning thresholds ($\tau_\kappa = \tau_{\mathrm{VIF}} = 10$; maximum observed $\kappa = 6.6$, VIF= 9.9), which bound the uniqueness and stability of the linearised least-squares estimates of the retained parameters (Supplementary Table S3, step 7) but do not require orthogonality; some selected pairs have cosine similarity near 0.9. Besides the admissibility condition $e_{\mathrm{fit}} \le \tau_e$, which all of them meet, 18 subsets also have a median $\cos\Delta \ge 0.9$, so that a single rescaling of the reduced response already achieves the threshold (Theorem 1), and two of these (Alkan and Perelson) also keep at least 89% of the sensitivity energy, so that the first-order error bound applies as well; Supplementary Table S1 gives these levels of guarantee for every problem. A low R_{var} or $\cos\Delta$ does not prevent a good reduction, because the re-estimated parameters compensate for the effects of the fixed ones; the cosine criterion (Theorem 1) is sufficient but not necessary for admissibility (in Raimundez, with 79 calibration parameters, the median $\cos\Delta$ is even negative while $e_{\mathrm{fit}} = 0.37$; Supplementary Note *System-by-system summary*). Stage 1 alone was sufficient in seven problems; in the other 25, the energy ordering selected parameters whose re-estimation could not reproduce the full model, and the finite-effect ordering of stage 2 was needed. The two non-admissible problems fail for different reasons. In Crauste, the published parameters lie at the edge of a regime in which the solution of the T-cell model grows without bound in finite time: changes of 1% in single parameters make the solution break down within the measured horizon, independently of the integrator tolerances, so the sensitivity matrix and the admissibility test are not defined and no local reduction method is applicable (Supplementary Note *System-by-system summary*). In

Beer, the selection stopped at 18 parameters because any further parameter violated the conditioning test, and the resulting subset had $e_{\mathrm{fit}} = 50\%$, above the threshold.

Re-estimation is essential. When the selected parameters are simply set to their perturbed values, without re-estimation, the median relative error e_{rel} exceeds τ_e in 23 of the 32 admissible problems (Fig. 2b); after re-estimation the median error e_{fit} is 14% (maximum 43.5%). In other words, the selected parameters do not replicate the effect of every individual perturbation; rather, adjusting them compensates for the perturbations of all other parameters in the measured outputs. This is precisely the property needed when the reduced model is fitted to data.

Prediction of held-out experiments

Reproducing the full model is not the same as predicting new data. We therefore split the measurements of each problem into training and test sets, by experimental condition when several conditions were available (21 problems) and by time otherwise, using the later time points as test set (11 problems); calibration or condition-specific parameters that appear only in the test set were excluded. The reduced model (re-estimating θ_S and θ_C) and the full model (re-estimating all parameters; in every problem except Lang, whose full re-estimation would require days to weeks of computation) were fitted to the training data starting from θ_0 and evaluated on the test data. In two problems a split was impossible (Bertozzi, whose selected parameters only act in the test conditions; Blasi, with a single condition and a single time point).

With the non-selected parameters kept at their published values θ_0, the reduced model predicted the held-out experiments at least as accurately as the full model re-estimated on the same training data (test χ^2/n within 5% of the full model or lower) in 27 of the 29 problems in which both could be compared (Fig. 3a; the three problems with noise-free data are not shown). The exceptions were Raia (test χ^2/n of 8.2 versus 5.1) and Chen (20.8 versus 15.1, both far above the noise level). In several problems the full model overfitted the training data and predicted much worse, for example Brannmark (test χ^2/n 5.8 versus 2,145), Weber (1.0 versus 226) and Zheng (1.6 versus 20.6). In five problems even θ_0 has $\chi^2/n > 10$, which indicates that the noise levels recorded in the benchmark do not match the scatter of the data; our simulations agree with the reference simulations of the benchmark (Supplementary Note *Verification of the simulator*), so these values reflect the published parameter sets rather than simulation errors.

This comparison favours the reduced model in one respect: θ_0 was estimated from all data, including the test experiments, and the reduced model inherits that information through the parameters it keeps fixed. Indeed, θ_0 itself predicted the test data better than the reduced model in 20 of 29 problems (Supplementary Note *Prediction of held-out experiments*). A leakage-free protocol in which the fixed values are first re-estimated on the training data makes the reduced model coincide with the full training fit, because the re-estimation then starts at the training optimum, and removes the advantage: this nested reduced model was worse than the θ_0-anchored one in 22 of 29 problems (Supplementary Note *Leakage-free nested validation*). The better prediction of the reduced model on real data therefore reflects the value of anchoring at published estimates, not a property of the selected subset alone.

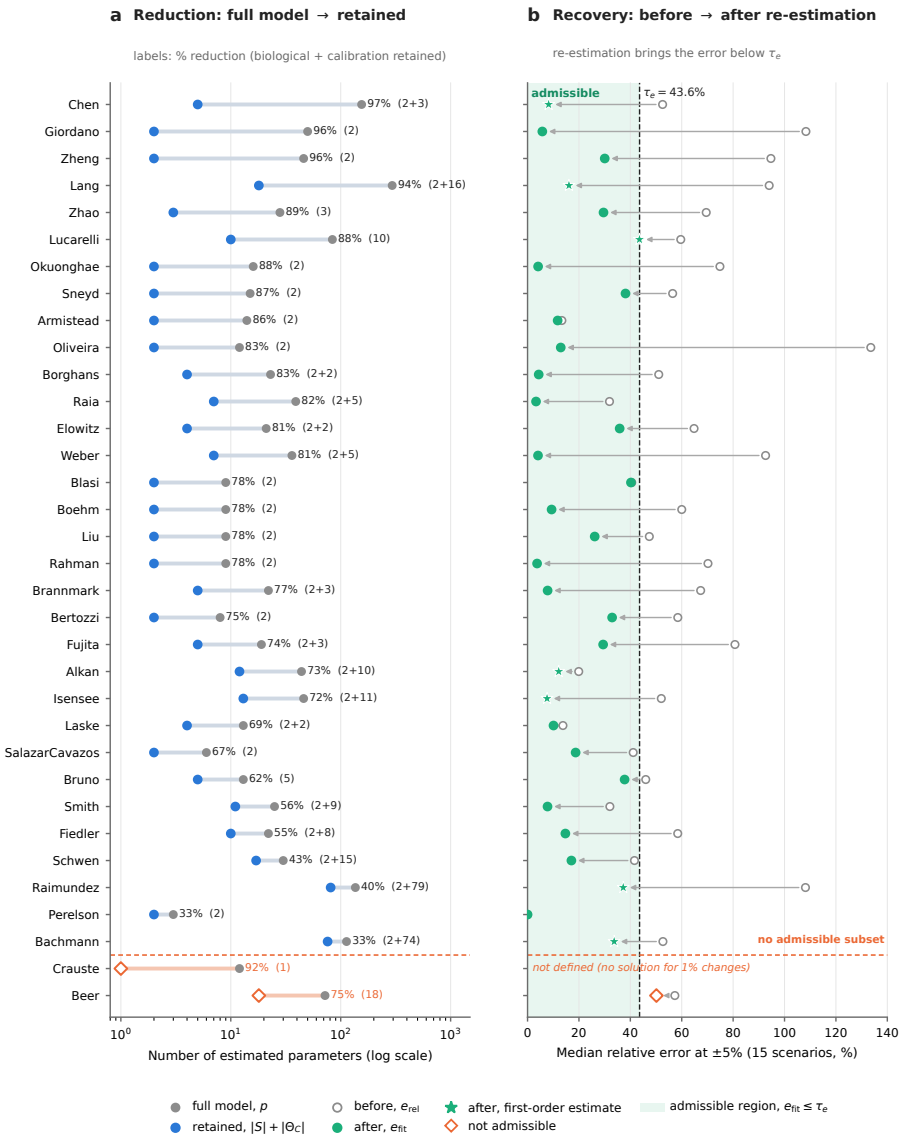


Fig. 2 Parameter reduction and recovery of the full-model output in 34 benchmark problems. Problems are ordered by the reduction achieved; the two without an admissible subset are at the bottom. **a**, Estimated parameters of the full model (p, grey) and parameters re-estimated in the reduced model (selected biological plus calibration parameters, blue). **b**, Median relative error over 15 random scenarios at ±5% before (e_{rel}, open circles) and after re-estimating the retained parameters (e_{fit}, green; stars, first-order estimate). The shaded region is the admissible region, $e_{\mathrm{fit}} \le \tau_e = 43.6\%$.

Table 1 Per-problem results. p, number of estimated parameters; m, number of measurements; $|\Theta_C|$, calibration parameters (always re-estimated); $|S|$, selected biological parameters; Stage, stage that produced the subset; e_{rel} and e_{fit}, median relative error over 15 scenarios at ±5% without and with re-estimation (admissibility: $e_{\text{fit}} \leq 43.6\%$; italic, not admissible; *, e_{fit} computed to first order because of simulation cost; †, not defined because the model has no solution on the measured horizon for 1% parameter changes); Pattern, behaviour of the median e_{fit} for perturbation sizes from ±1% to ±50% (A, admissible at all sizes; B, admissible up to at least ±20% and not beyond; C, irregular; D, not admissible at ±10% or less; –, not applicable); Test χ^2/n, mean squared noise-scaled residual on held-out experiments for the reduced and the full model, both re-estimated on the training experiments (values near 1 mean errors of the size of the measurement noise; –, not evaluable or not run).

System	p	m	$\lvert\Theta_C\rvert$	$\lvert S\rvert$	Stage	e_{rel} (%)	e_{fit} (%)	Pattern	Test χ^2/n reduced / full
Alkan	44	1733	10	2	1	20	12.1*	A	2.75 / 3.38
Armistead	14	58	0	2	2	13	11.7	B	1.22 / 1.37
Bachmann	113	541	74	2	2	53	33.7*	A	4.77 / 12.23
Beer	72	27132	0	18	2	57	*50.1**	–	–
Bertozzi	8	22	0	2	2	58	32.9	B	–
Blasi	9	252	0	2	1	41	40.2	B	–
Boehm	9	48	0	2	2	60	9.4	A	2.57 / 11.35
Borghans	23	111	2	2	2	51	4.3	A	0.74 / 0.74
Brannmark	22	43	3	2	2	67	7.8	A	5.79 / 2.15e+03
Bruno	13	77	0	5	1	46	37.8	A	0.91 / 7.86
Chen	155	120	3	2	2	53	8.2*	A	20.77 / 15.12
Crauste	12	21	0	1	2	–	*n.d.*†	–	–
Elowitz	21	58	2	2	1	65	35.8	B	1.50 / 4.45
Fiedler	22	72	8	2	2	58	14.7	A	11.21 / 14.11
Fujita	19	144	3	2	2	81	29.4	A	5.94 / 8.04
Giordano	50	313	0	2	2	108	5.8	A	<0.01 / 0.06
Isensee	46	687	11	2	1	52	7.6*	A	1.08 / 1.08
Lang	294	9600	16	2	2	94	16.1*	A	8.98 / –
Laske	13	42	2	2	1	14	10.1	A	0.76 / 1.88
Liu	9	100	0	2	2	47	26.1	A	0.95 / 1.02
Lucarelli	84	1755	0	10	2	60	43.5*	C	1.64 / 3.22
Okuonghae	16	92	0	2	2	75	4.1	A	4.67e4 / 1.22e5
Oliveira	12	120	0	2	2	134	12.9	A	915 / 8.15e4
Perelson	3	16	0	2	1	0	0.0	A	<0.01 / <0.01
Rahman	9	23	0	2	2	70	3.7	A	<0.01 / 0.03
Raia	39	205	5	2	2	32	3.3	A	8.23 / 5.10
Raimundez	136	627	79	2	2	108	37.2*	A	1.19 / 1.46
SalazarCavazos	6	18	0	2	2	41	18.7	A	102 / 124
Schwen	30	286	15	2	2	42	17.1	A	8.20 / 8.40
Smith	25	62	9	2	2	32	7.8	A	1.50e4 / 1.50e4
Sneyd	15	135	0	2	2	56	38.1	A	2.22 / 2.55
Weber	36	135	5	2	2	93	4.1	A	1.00 / 226
Zhao	28	82	0	3	2	70	29.6	A	0.35 / 0.35
Zheng	46	60	0	2	2	95	30.0	A	1.58 / 20.60

To measure prediction without this confound we generated synthetic data from a known truth θ^* that differs from θ_0 by up to $\pm 20\%$ in every estimable parameter, with Gaussian noise of the recorded size, so that θ_0 carries no information about the test data, and repeated the experiment with 20 random seeds (Supplementary Note *Synthetic prediction experiment*). Among the cases in which the parameter change exceeded the noise, the reduced model reached a relative prediction error $e_{\mathrm{pred}} \leq \tau_e$ in 55% (187 of 340; 29–67% depending on the seed) and predicted at least as well as the full model in 56% (159 of 282; 40–73%). The outcome was stable within each problem and divided the benchmark into two groups (Fig. 3b): the reduced model predicted better in almost every seed where the full model is over-parameterised for the data (for example Weber 20 of 20 seeds, Zheng 18 of 20, Brannmark 17 of 18, Isensee 12 of 12) and worse where the data inform all parameters (Oliveira 0 of 20, Fujita 1 of 18, Okuonghae 2 of 20). On data that θ_0 has not seen, the two-parameter models thus predict on par with the full models overall, with a consistent advantage when the full model overfits.

Comparison with existing selection criteria

We compared the subsets of our method with those of four existing criteria that also select which parameters to estimate: pivoted QR of the normalised sensitivity matrix[32]; the collinearity index of Brun *et al.*[14] (the most important parameters with collinearity index at most 10 and the largest determinant measure); Morris screening of elementary effects over the whole range $[\theta_0/10,\ 10\theta_0]$[12]; and profile likelihood[5, 29], retaining the parameters with the narrowest profile-likelihood confidence intervals. To compare the criteria rather than the subset sizes, every criterion chose the same number $k = |S|$ of biological parameters as our method, from the same training data, and every subset was evaluated with the same three tests: prediction of the held-out experiments, reproduction of the full model (the admissibility test of our method) and prediction of synthetic data (Methods; Table 2 and Fig. 4). Two further baselines re-estimated only the calibration parameters ($k = 0$) or k biological parameters drawn at random (median of 20 draws). Profile likelihood could not be computed for the five problems with more than 60 free parameters, and Chen and Lang were excluded from the Brun and Morris comparisons for the same reason (Supplementary Notes *Pivoted QR selection*, *Profile likelihood* and *Brun and Morris selections*).

Profile likelihood gives an independent view of how many parameters the data determine. Over the 26 problems in which it could be computed, the median number of biological parameters whose profile exceeded the 95% threshold on both sides was two (17% of the biological parameters), six problems had none, and 14 had two or fewer. This agrees with the size of the subsets found by our method, although the two criteria rarely chose the same parameters (none or one in common in most problems): a flat profile means that other free parameters can compensate for changes in a parameter, whereas our method asks which parameters suffice when all others are fixed at θ_0.

On real data, the criteria were practically indistinguishable (Fig. 4c). Pairwise Wilcoxon tests over problems found no significant difference between our subsets and

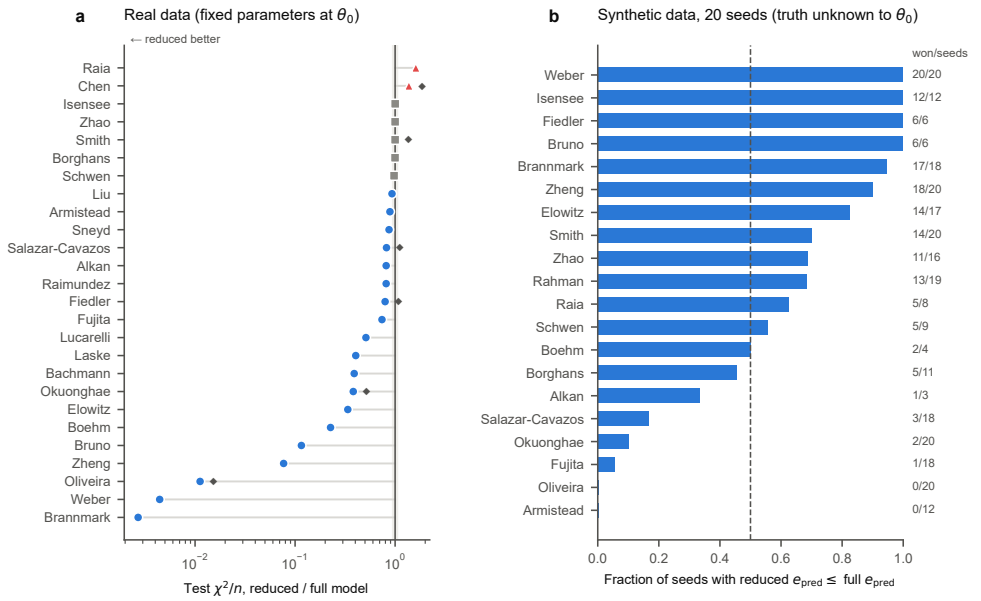


Fig. 3 Prediction of held-out experiments by the reduced and the full model. a, Real data: ratio of the test χ^2/n (mean squared noise-scaled residual on the held-out experiments) of the reduced model to that of the full model re-estimated on the same training data, on a logarithmic scale ($n = 26$ problems), with the non-selected parameters kept at θ_0. Left of the vertical line (circles) the reduced model predicts better; the grey band marks equivalence within 5% (squares); triangles mark worse predictions; ♦ flags a reduced test χ^2/n above 10, where a favourable ratio does not imply a good absolute fit. **b**, Synthetic data from a known truth, which θ_0 has not seen: for each problem, fraction of the 20 seeds in which the reduced model predicted at least as well as the full model (smaller e_{pred}), among the seeds in which the parameter change exceeded the noise (seeds won / seeds with signal on the right; problems with fewer than three such seeds are not shown). Problems are ordered by this fraction. Problems without a training/test split (Bertozzi, Blasi), without a full re-estimation (Lang, and in **b** also Chen, Raimundez and Bachmann) or with noise-free data (**a**: Giordano, Perelson, Rahman) are not shown. The comparison with the published estimate θ_0 and the scatter plots are given in Supplementary Note *Prediction of held-out experiments*.

those of Brun ($p = 0.25$), Morris ($p = 0.33$), profile likelihood ($p = 0.62$) or random subsets ($p = 0.20$); pivoted QR and calibration-only re-estimation were slightly better (median ratio of test χ^2/n 0.99 and 0.98; $p = 0.02$ and 0.003). Only in Oliveira did the specific choice matter, with our subset predicting 22 to 500 times better than the random and calibration-only baselines (Supplementary Note *Comparison on real data*). As expected for sloppy models[10], many different small subsets fit the training data and predict similarly when the remaining parameters are kept at θ_0, so this test does not discriminate between criteria.

The criteria differed clearly in whether their subsets reproduced the full model (Fig. 4a). At the perturbation size used by our method (±5%), our subsets were admissible in all 29 comparable problems, against 24 of 29 for Brun, 21 of 29 for Morris, 17 of 26 for profile likelihood and 13 of 29 for pivoted QR, and there was no problem in which another criterion produced an admissible subset and ours did not (Supplementary Note *Admissibility of the subsets of other criteria*). Because our method selects subsets precisely by this test, we repeated it at ±20%, a level used by none of the criteria: our subsets remained admissible in 28 of 29 problems, against 23, 21, 17 and 14 for the other criteria (exact McNemar test over problems: $p = 0.06$ against Brun, 0.02 against Morris, 0.008 against profile likelihood and 10^{-4} against pivoted QR). The same difference appeared in prediction when θ_0 carries no information about the test data (Fig. 4b): over 280 synthetic cases in 23 problems, our subsets reached $e_{\mathrm{pred}} \leq \tau_e$ in 54% of cases, Brun's in 55%, Morris's in 48%, those of profile likelihood in 39% and those of pivoted QR in 34%; resampling whole problems, the advantage was 20 percentage points over pivoted QR (95% confidence interval 7–33) and 15 over profile likelihood (4–27), whereas the differences from Morris (+6; −3 to +15) and Brun (−1; −8 to +4) were not significant. The median prediction error itself did not differ significantly between criteria (Supplementary Note *Comparison of selection criteria on synthetic data*). The distinguishing property of our method is therefore not a lower average prediction error but reliability: its subsets are verified to reproduce the full model and, as a consequence, fail less often on new data; Brun's collinearity index, which shares the sensitivity-based ranking, comes closest.

Robustness to the size of parameter changes

Admissibility is decided with perturbations of ±5%. To determine how far the conclusion extends, we kept each final subset fixed and repeated the evaluation with perturbations of ±1, 5, 10, 20, 30, 40 and 50% (15 scenarios per level). The scenarios are paired: the same fifteen random directions $u^{(k)}$ are used at every level, $\theta^{(k)} = \theta_0 \odot (1 + \varepsilon u^{(k)})$, so that differences between levels are due only to the size ε, and the ±5% level reproduces the scenarios of the selection. We classified the behaviour of the median e_{fit} into four patterns: A, admissible at all levels; B, admissible up to at least ±20% and not thereafter; C, irregular (failing and then passing again); D, failing at ±10% or less.

All 32 admissible problems were evaluated. Twenty-seven follow pattern A (Fig. 5): their median e_{fit} stays below the threshold up to ±50%, typically varying by only a few percentage points across levels. Four follow pattern B: Armistead, whose error grows steadily from 3% at ±1% to 63% at ±50%, and Bertozzi, Blasi and

Table 2 Comparison of selection criteria. All criteria choose the same number $k = |S|$ of biological parameters as our method and are evaluated with the same protocol. Admissible: subsets whose re-estimation reproduces the full model (median $e_{\text{fit}} \leq \tau_e$) for parameter changes of ±5% and ±20%. Synthetic: fraction of the 280 common synthetic cases with signal (23 problems, 20 seeds) in which $e_{\text{pred}} \leq \tau_e$, and difference from our method with a 95% confidence interval from resampling problems. Real data: median ratio of the test χ^2/n to that of our method (below 1, better than ours; non-selected parameters at θ_0) and Wilcoxon p-value over problems. Profile likelihood was feasible only for problems with at most 60 free parameters. Per-problem values are given in the Supplementary Notes on the comparison of selection criteria.

		Admissible		Synthetic: $e_{\text{pred}} \leq \tau_e$		Real data
Criterion	Basis	±5%	±20%	Rate	Ours − criterion (95% CI)	χ^2 ratio (p)
Our method	Sensitivity, κ/VIF, re-estimation test, backward elimination	**29/29**	**28/29**	54%	–	–
Brun	Sensitivity and collinearity index	24/29	23/29	55%	−1 (−8 to +4)	1.00 (0.25)
Morris	Global elementary effects	21/29	21/29	48%	+6 (−3 to +15)	1.00 (0.33)
Profile likelihood	Repeated re-estimation of the full model	17/26	17/26	39%	+15 (+4 to +27)	1.00 (0.62)
Pivoted QR	Linear independence of sensitivities	13/29	14/29	34%	+20 (+7 to +33)	0.99 (0.02)
Random	k parameters at random (median of 20)	–	–	–	–	1.00 (0.20)
Calibration only	No biological parameter ($k = 0$)	–	–	–	–	0.98 (0.003)

Elowitz, which are close to the threshold already at ±5% and cross it between ±20% and ±30%. Lucarelli is the only case of pattern C: its median error stays between 43% and 47% at all levels, that is, on the threshold rather than clearly above or below it. No problem follows pattern D. The median does not show how many individual scenarios are reproduced, so we also report the pass rate, the fraction of the fifteen scenarios with $e_{\text{fit}} \leq \tau_e$ (Fig. 5b). At ±5%, 15 of the 32 problems reproduce the full model in all fifteen scenarios and the median pass rate is 93%; the other 17 have at least one scenario above the threshold. Among the 27 problems of pattern A, 10 pass every scenario at every level, whereas 7 (Borghans, Bruno, Fujita, Liu, Sneyd, Zhao, Zheng) fall to a pass rate of 60–73% at some level, so their median is below the threshold while four to six of the fifteen scenarios are not reproduced. The reductions therefore remain valid well beyond the ±5% used for selection in most problems, whereas problems that are admissible only with a small margin at ±5% are those that lose admissibility for large changes. The full distribution of the error for every problem and level (interquartile range, 5–95% range, maximum and pass rate) is given in Supplementary Note *Robustness to the size of parameter changes* (Supplementary Tables S10 and S11 and Supplementary Fig. S2).

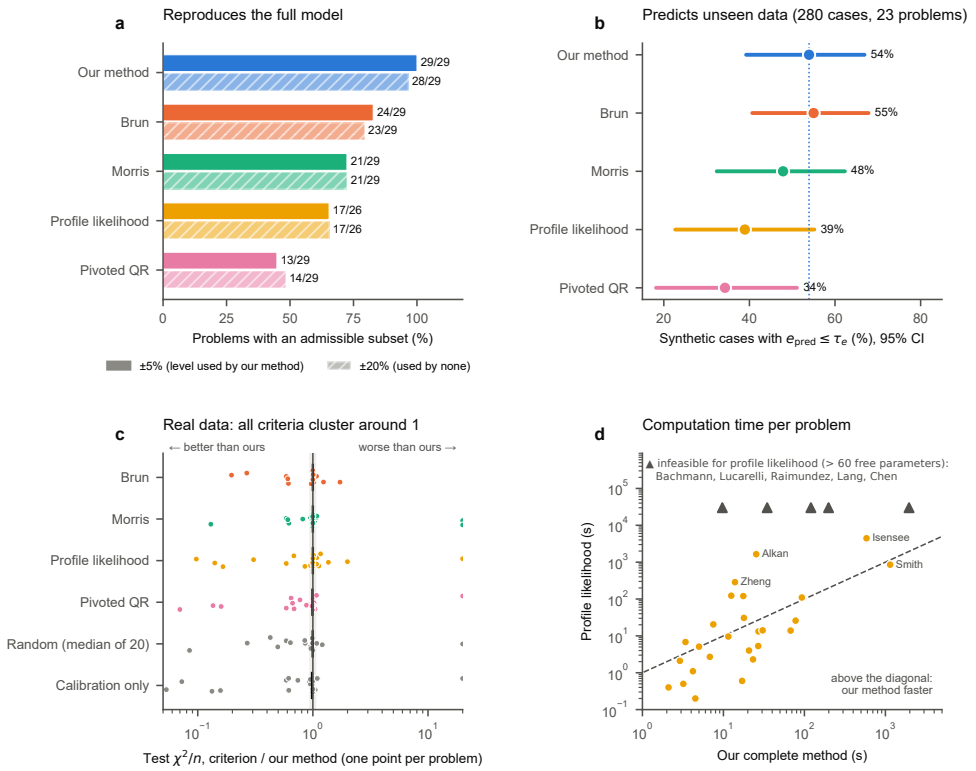


Fig. 4 Our method compared with four existing selection criteria. a, Number of problems in which the subset of each criterion is admissible, i.e. its re-estimation reproduces the full model, for parameter changes of ±5% (the level used by our method) and ±20% (used by none). **b**, Fraction of synthetic cases in which the subset predicts the truth within τ_e (280 common cases, 23 problems, 20 seeds), with 95% confidence intervals from resampling problems. **c**, Real data: ratio of the test χ^2/n of each criterion to that of our method, one point per problem, vertical bar at the median (log scale; grey band, ±5%; values outside the axis are drawn at its edge); all criteria cluster around 1. **d**, Computation time of our complete method and of profile likelihood per problem (log scales); points above the diagonal are faster with our method; problems in which profile likelihood was infeasible are shown at the top.

Sensitivity to method settings and computational cost

The method depends on a finite-difference step δ, integrator tolerances, the perturbation size used for admissibility and four thresholds (τ_R, τ_κ, τ_{VIF}, τ_e). We re-ran the complete method on the 26 small and medium problems changing one setting at a time (Supplementary Note *Sensitivity to the method settings*). The selected subset was identical to the baseline in all 26 problems for $\delta = 0.1\%$ and 5%, for both sets of integrator tolerances and for τ_R between 0.80 and 0.95; with perturbations of ±1% or ±10% it differed only in Zhao, where backward elimination removed one of its three parameters, and admissibility changed only for Perelson at ±1%, where the perturbed output change falls below the numerical noise floor. The κ/VIF threshold changed the subset in three or four problems without changing the

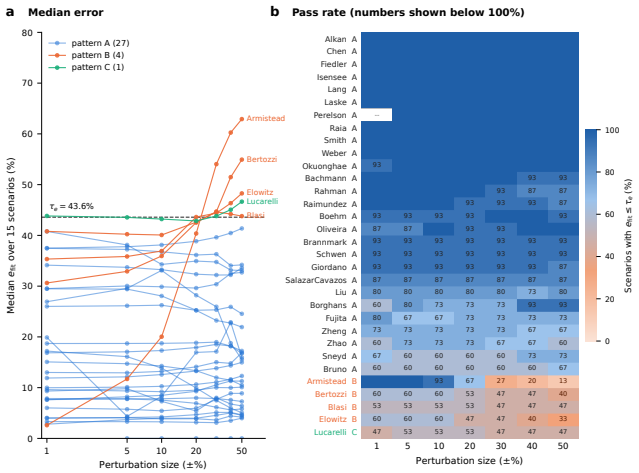


Fig. 5 Robustness of the selected subsets to the size of parameter changes. a, Median relative error after re-estimation (e_{fit}) over 15 random scenarios per level as a function of the perturbation size, for the final subset of each of the 32 admissible problems, coloured by robustness pattern (A, admissible at all levels; B, admissible up to at least ±20%; C, irregular); dashed line, $\tau_e = 43.6\%$. **b**, Pass rate: percentage of the scenarios with $e_{\mathrm{fit}} \leq \tau_e$, with the value written when it is below 100%. The same fifteen random directions are used at every level. –, no valid scenario (Perelson at ±1%, where the output change is below the numerical noise floor).

number of admissible problems. As expected, the error threshold has the largest influence: requiring $e_{\mathrm{fit}} \leq 10\%$ leaves 22 admissible problems with a mean of 3.6 biological parameters, whereas τ_e between 0.30 and 0.50 gives 25 admissible problems with 2.1–2.4 parameters. The threshold therefore acts as an accuracy–parsimony trade-off; it is set through the cosine requirement $c = 0.9$ by $\tau_e = \sqrt{1 - c^2}$ (Theorem 1), so the only choice is c, whose effect is covered by the scan. The minimum subset size $k_{\min} = 2$ is a design choice: a single biological parameter, re-estimated with the calibration parameters, already reached the threshold in 16 of 27 problems examined; in the synthetic prediction experiment the selected subset predicted better than the best single parameter in 10 of these 16, but on real data the single parameter had the lower test χ^2/n in 11 of 16 (Supplementary Note *Single-parameter subsets*). The admissibility test uses the median over $N = 15$ random scenarios rather than requiring all of them to pass, because individual scenarios near the boundary of the parameter domain can fail due to ODE nonlinearity; six problems pass with 8–9 of the 15 scenarios. For Lucarelli, the first-order median e_{fit} (0.435) lies within 10^{-3} of τ_e, so its admissibility is borderline, although it is stable across perturbation sizes (43–47% from ±1% to ±50%). The random seed and the number of scenarios N were not varied.

The cost of the selection is dominated by the computation of J ($2p$ simulations) and of the stage-2 ordering (p simulations), so the number of sensitivity simulations grows linearly with the number of parameters; all of them are independent and can run in parallel, and the selection, condition-number tests and first-order e_{fit} only use

linear algebra on J. The admissibility test adds 15 scenarios with re-estimation for each candidate subset, a cost that depends on the simulation time and on the number of retained parameters rather than on p. Run from scratch, the complete method (selection, admissibility and backward elimination) took from a few seconds to 33 minutes per problem (median 19 s; Chen, with 35 s per simulation, was the slowest), on a shared multi-core server (Supplementary Note *Computational cost*). Profile likelihood, which requires repeated re-estimation of the full model, was much slower on problems with expensive simulations (Alkan 27 min against 25 s for our method; Zheng 5 min against 14 s; Isensee more than one hour against 10 min) and could not be completed for the five problems with more than 60 free parameters (up to 294), which our method processed in 10 s to 33 min (Fig. 4d). On small problems, profile likelihood was as fast as or faster than our method, because the admissibility test has a fixed cost. On state trajectories, the 4,231-parameter Froehlich model required 12,693 simulations and 2.6 h for the sensitivities; for models of this size on measured outputs, forward or adjoint sensitivity equations[21] compute J at the cost of a few simulations.

Formal verification of the mathematical foundations

The mathematical statements on which the method relies and that are verified in Lean 4 with Mathlib are summarised in Supplementary Table S3; the complete development comprises 31 modules with 289 theorems and lemmas and 28 verified benchmark models; Supplementary Tables S5 and S6 give the notation of the formalisation and the statement of every theorem and lemma, and all proofs compile together with a single command (Code availability). None of the proofs uses unproved assumptions (`sorry`) or additional axioms. Two statements are central to the method:

Theorem 1. *For vectors $d \neq 0$ and $b \neq 0$ in a real inner-product space,* $\min_{\lambda \in \mathbb{R}} \|d - \lambda b\| / \|d\| = \sqrt{1 - \cos^2(d, b)}$.

Theorem 2. *Let $\mathcal{A}$ be any admissibility predicate on finite sets and S an admissible set. Backward elimination (removing one element at a time whenever the remaining set is still admissible, until no element can be removed) returns an admissible subset of S from which no element can be removed without losing admissibility.*

Theorem 1 relates the threshold τ_e to the cosine: whenever $\cos \Delta \geq c$, rescaling the reduced response already gives a relative error of at most $\sqrt{1 - c^2}$, and re-estimating several parameters can only do better to first order. The converse does not hold, and admissibility itself is decided by the numerically computed e_{fit}. Theorem 2 gives the precise sense in which the selected subsets are minimal: no parameter can be removed, although a different, smaller admissible subset that is not contained in the result may exist. The other verified statements cover the remaining steps: re-estimating more parameters never increases the fitting error and $e_{\mathrm{fit}} \leq e_{\mathrm{rel}}$; the selection keeps κ and VIF below their thresholds and permanently discarding a rejected candidate is correct because both quantities can only increase when parameters are added; κ and VIF bounds imply that the linearised least-squares

problem for the retained parameters has a unique and stable solution (which is not a proof of identifiability of the nonlinear model); error bounds on the states transfer to the measured outputs, including logarithmic transformations; and the first-order version of e_{fit} used for the largest models differs from the exact one by a second-order term. The verification is local: it does not prove that a subset remains adequate far from θ_0, which is assessed empirically above. The theorems are implications; the quantities to which they are applied (κ, VIF, R_{var}, e_{fit}) are computed in floating point, and Supplementary Table S4 states the scope of each guarantee and the numerical values that connect it with our results. The model files used by Lean were checked against the SBML models of the benchmark, with agreement to rounding error (Supplementary Note *Verified benchmark models*, Supplementary Table S7, with the complete data of one model in Supplementary Table S8). Figure 6 summarises how the two parts fit together: Python performs every computation on the benchmark problems, Lean proves the general statements of Supplementary Table S3 and checks the hypotheses of each model, and a conclusion of Supplementary Table S3 applies to a result of the paper only when both the model hypotheses are verified and the computed quantities satisfy the inequalities that the theorem requires.

Discussion

The central finding is that, for most published systems biology models with real data, the measured outputs can be reproduced by re-estimating only two biological parameters together with the measurement calibration parameters. Profile likelihood, applied independently, likewise finds a median of two parameters that the data determine. This is consistent with the sloppy-model picture[10], but it is a more concrete and practical statement: it refers to the outputs that were actually measured, under the actual experimental conditions and noise levels, and it is checked by re-estimation rather than inferred from the sensitivity spectrum. It is a statement about sufficiency, not about predictive superiority: on synthetic data that the published estimate has not seen, the two-parameter models predict on par with the full models, better when the full model is over-parameterised for the data and worse when the data inform all of its parameters, and their advantage on real data reflects the information contained in the published values at which the other parameters are fixed.

The comparison with existing criteria clarifies what the method adds. When the remaining parameters are kept at their published values, subsets chosen by pivoted QR, Brun's collinearity index, Morris screening, profile likelihood or at random predict held-out experiments about equally well; many small subsets are adequate, and the test error alone cannot tell them apart. The criteria do differ in whether their subsets actually reproduce the full model: those of our method did so in every comparable problem, whereas the other criteria failed in 17–55% of the problems, also at a perturbation size that none of them, ours included, was tuned for. This reliability carried over to prediction on data that the published values do not inform, where our subsets reached the accuracy threshold significantly more often than those of pivoted QR and profile likelihood. Brun's collinearity index, which, like stage 1 of our method, combines sensitivity with a redundancy test, came closest and did not

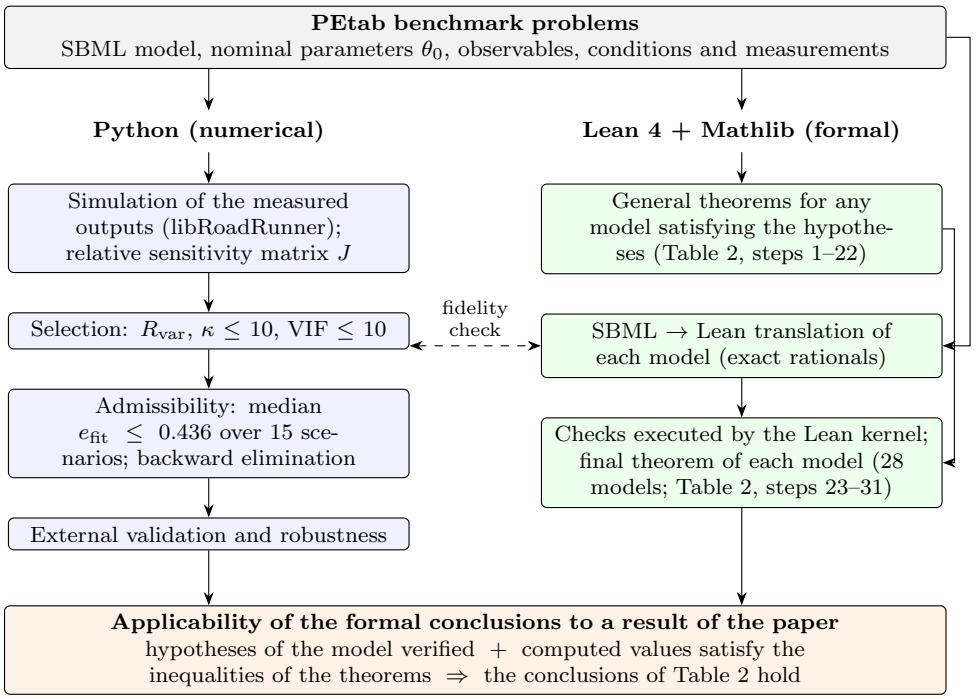


Fig. 6 Architecture of the formal and numerical verification. Python (left) performs all computations on the PEtab problems: simulation, sensitivities, selection, admissibility, validation and robustness. Lean 4 with Mathlib (right) proves the general theorems behind each step of the method (Supplementary Table S3) and, for 28 benchmark models translated from SBML, checks with the Lean kernel that the hypotheses on the dynamics hold. The translation of each model is compared independently with the SBML model (dashed arrow; Supplementary Note *Verified benchmark models*). A formal conclusion applies to a result of the paper when the hypotheses of the model are verified and the numerical quantities computed in Python satisfy the inequalities that the theorem requires (bottom); Supplementary Table S4 gives, for each guarantee, what it establishes and what it does not.

differ significantly in prediction; what distinguishes our method from it is that the subset is verified by re-estimation and made minimal by backward elimination, and that the verification makes failures visible (Beer, Crauste) instead of returning an untested subset. The ranking by sensitivity energy itself is not new: E_j is the diagonal of the Fisher information matrix for the scaled outputs and, up to a constant, the squared importance measure of Brun *et al.*[14]; the contribution lies in the verification that follows it. The two-stage design reflects a practical observation: ranking by energy (stage 1) was sufficient in only seven problems, whereas ranking by finite-perturbation effects (stage 2) was needed in most, because energy measures how strongly a parameter moves the outputs, not whether adjusting it can compensate for changes in other parameters.

The method is also practical. The number of sensitivity simulations grows linearly with the number of parameters and they can run in parallel; the complete method, including the admissibility test, took from seconds to about half an hour

per problem and handled models with up to 294 parameters, for which profile likelihood, which repeatedly re-estimates the full model[5, 29], was infeasible. It is applied before any new calibration, uses the published parameter values as its starting point, is insensitive to its numerical settings, and its subsets remain adequate for parameter changes of up to $\pm 50\%$ in most problems. Each step rests on statements proved in Lean 4. Other approaches answer different questions: likelihood-based observability analysis[7] assesses the uncertainty of predictions after calibration, Bayesian approaches[22] require many more simulations, structural identifiability analysis[2–4] addresses ideal noise-free data rather than a given experimental design, manifold-based sloppiness methods[28] identify emergent parameter combinations and rewrite the model rather than select individual parameters, balanced truncation[23, 24] reduces state variables rather than parameters, and hierarchical optimisation[31] eliminates calibration parameters during fitting without selecting among biological ones.

Several limitations should be noted. First, the analysis is local: sensitivities are computed at the published estimate θ_0, which is assumed to be a good fit to the data, and admissibility is tested around it; problems that are admissible with a small margin at $\pm 5\%$ (Bertozzi, Blasi, Elowitz, Lucarelli) are those that lose admissibility for larger changes. Second, because the non-selected parameters stay at θ_0, the reduced model's prediction of real held-out data benefits from the information that θ_0 already contains; a leakage-free nested protocol removes this benefit, and prediction on data that θ_0 has not seen is on par with, not better than, the full model. Third, the minimum subset size of two is a design choice; a single parameter already reaches the threshold in about half of the problems. Fourth, for the eight problems with the most expensive simulations the fitting error was computed to first order, and on small problems the admissibility test makes the method no faster than profile likelihood. Fifth, the method assumes smooth models, Gaussian noise with the recorded standard deviations and re-estimable calibration parameters; in five problems the recorded noise levels do not match the scatter of the data, in problems with many calibration parameters (Bachmann, Raimundez) the reduced problem is still sizeable, one benchmark problem with 9,169 experimental conditions was too expensive to analyse on its measured outputs with finite differences, and two problems had no admissible subset. Finally, the formal verification covers the mathematical steps of the method and the regularity of the translated models, not the numerical computations themselves, which we cross-checked against the reference simulations of the benchmark.

The social cognitive theory model, which motivated this work, illustrates the same behaviour outside molecular biology: with a single measured output the full estimation problem is ill-posed, and the conditioning test identifies two parameters that carry the information in that output. In practice, the method can be used as a preprocessing step: before calibrating a large model, select the few biological parameters that the data can inform, verify that re-estimating them reproduces the full model, keep the rest at literature values, and check the reduced model on held-out experiments. The threshold τ_e provides an explicit trade-off between accuracy and parsimony. Natural extensions include computing J with forward or adjoint

sensitivity equations for genome-scale models, combining sensitivities at several operating points, and using the selected subsets to guide experimental design[25].

Methods

Models, data and simulation

We used the problems of the PEtab benchmark collection[8, 18] that provide real measurements, an SBML model and nominal parameter values (34 problems; Table 1). Each problem specifies the observables g_i, their transformation h (linear, log or $\log_{10}$), the noise standard deviation σ_i of each measurement, the experimental conditions (parameter or initial-value overrides) and, where applicable, pre-equilibration conditions. Models were simulated with libRoadRunner[26] (CVODE, relative and absolute tolerances 10^{-7} and 10^{-10}). Initial assignments that depend on parameters were re-evaluated for every parameter vector, condition-specific overrides were applied before simulation, pre-equilibration was run to steady state before the main simulation, and models with discontinuous inputs were integrated piecewise between discontinuities. Simulated observables were compared with the reference simulations distributed with the benchmark wherever available (Supplementary Note *Verification of the simulator*, Supplementary Table S9).

Social cognitive theory model

The model[16, 17] has six states x_i (constructs of social cognitive theory[15]) and obeys $\dot{x} = A(\theta)x + B(\theta)u$, $y = x_4$ (behaviour), with $A_{ii} = -1/\tau_i$, $A_{ij} = \beta_{ij}/\tau_i$ for the ten couplings $\beta_{14}, \beta_{21}, \beta_{25}, \beta_{31}, \beta_{34}, \beta_{42}, \beta_{43}, \beta_{45}, \beta_{46}, \beta_{54}$, and input gains $\gamma_{33}, \gamma_{35}, \gamma_{36}, \gamma_{57}, \gamma_{64}, \gamma_{68}$ divided by the time constant of the receiving construct (γ_{35} enters with negative sign; 22 parameters). The data are 31 daily records of one participant[17]: six measured inputs and daily steps as output, each standardised to zero mean and unit variance. The model is simulated from $x(0) = 0$ with inputs held constant over each day (exact zero-order-hold discretisation with the matrix exponential), and the output of day k is x_4 at the end of that day. θ_0 minimises the mean squared error by differential evolution, following the estimation framework of ref. [17] (strategy best1bin, population factor 4, 60 generations, Latin hypercube initialisation, no polishing; 5,368 function evaluations; seed 2026) within the bounds $\beta \in [-1.5, 1.5]$, $\gamma \in [0, 3]$, $\tau \in [0.3, 12]$, subject to stability ($\max \mathrm{Re}\, \lambda(A) \leq -10^{-3}$); the 100 runs with seeds 2026–2125 were used only to assess non-identifiability. The noise level σ is the standard deviation of the residuals at θ_0 (0.35 in standardised units). Because couplings may be negative, the reduced refit uses $\theta_j = \mathrm{sign}(\theta_{0,j}) \exp(v_j)$. All other settings are as for the benchmark problems. For validation, the reduced and full models were refitted to days 1–24 by least squares from θ_0 within the same bounds and with the stability constraint, and the full model also by the same differential-evolution search; both were evaluated on days 25–31.

Measured outputs and parameter classes

For a parameter vector $\theta \in \mathbb{R}^p$ (in the units of the benchmark, excluding noise parameters), the vector of scaled outputs is $y(\theta) \in \mathbb{R}^m$ with entries

$$y_i(\theta) = \frac{h\big(g_i(x(t_i;\theta,c_i),\theta)\big)}{\sigma_i}, \qquad i = 1,\dots,m, \tag{1}$$

where $x(t;\theta,c)$ is the state trajectory under condition c and (t_i, c_i) are the time and condition of measurement i. Parameters that appear in the SBML model are biological (Θ_B); parameters that appear only in the observation functions and not in the model or the condition table (scalings and offsets) are calibration parameters (Θ_C). Only biological parameters are candidates for selection; calibration parameters are always re-estimated.

Sensitivities, energy and conditioning

The relative sensitivity matrix $J \in \mathbb{R}^{m\times p}$ is computed by central differences,

$$J_{:,j} = \frac{y(\theta_0 + \delta\theta_{0,j}e_j) - y(\theta_0 - \delta\theta_{0,j}e_j)}{2\delta}, \tag{2}$$

which approximates $\partial y/\partial \log\theta_j$. The energy of parameter j is $E_j = \|J_{:,j}\|^2 = (J^\top J)_{jj}$ and the fraction of energy captured by a subset $S \subseteq \Theta_B$ is $R_{\mathrm{var}}(S) = \sum_{j\in S} E_j / \sum_{j\in\Theta_B} E_j$. For a subset S, the columns of J_S are normalised to unit length, $Z = J_S\,\mathrm{diag}(\|J_{:,j}\|)^{-1}$; the condition number is $\kappa(S) = \sigma_{\max}(Z)/\sigma_{\min}(Z)$ and the largest variance inflation factor is $\mathrm{VIF}(S) = \max_j [(Z^\top Z)^{-1}]_{jj}$[13, 14]. Normalisation removes differences of scale between parameters, so that κ and VIF measure only the angles between sensitivity directions.

Selection

Greedy selection. Candidates are visited in a given order. A candidate j is accepted if $\kappa(S\cup\{j\}) \le \tau_\kappa$ and $\mathrm{VIF}(S\cup\{j\}) \le \tau_{\mathrm{VIF}}$; otherwise it is discarded permanently. Because κ and VIF can only increase when columns are added, a discarded candidate would also be rejected later. *Stage 1* visits biological parameters in decreasing order of E_j and stops when $R_{\mathrm{var}}(S) \ge \tau_R$. *Stage 2*, used if the stage-1 subset is not admissible, visits biological parameters in decreasing order of the finite-perturbation effect $s_j = \|y(\theta_0 + \eta\theta_{0,j}e_j) - y(\theta_0)\|$ and stops at the first admissible subset. *Backward elimination* visits the parameters of the selected subset and removes each one whose removal leaves the subset admissible.

Admissibility and re-estimation

Admissibility is evaluated on N random scenarios $\theta^{(k)} = \theta_0 \odot (1 + \varepsilon u^{(k)})$, with $u^{(k)}$ uniform in $[-1,1]^p$. For each scenario let $\Delta y_{\mathrm{full}} = y(\theta^{(k)}) - y(\theta_0)$. The relative error without re-estimation is $e_{\mathrm{rel}} = \|\Delta y_{\mathrm{full}} - \Delta y_S\|/\|\Delta y_{\mathrm{full}}\|$, where Δy_S is the output

change when only the parameters in $S \cup \Theta_C$ take their scenario values, and the cosine similarity is $\cos\Delta = \langle \Delta y_{\text{full}}, \Delta y_S \rangle / (\|\Delta y_{\text{full}}\| \|\Delta y_S\|)$. The relative error after re-estimation is

$$e_{\text{fit}} = \min_{\theta_S, \theta_C} \frac{\|y(\theta_S, \theta_C, \theta_{0,\overline{S}}) - y(\theta^{(k)})\|}{\|\Delta y_{\text{full}}\|}, \tag{3}$$

where $\theta_{0,\overline{S}}$ denotes the nominal values of all other biological parameters. The minimisation is carried out in $\log|\theta|$ within $[|\theta_0|/10,\ 10|\theta_0|]$ by a trust-region reflective least-squares method (SciPy[27], at most $100(|S| + |\Theta_C| + 1)$ function evaluations), from two starting points (the scenario value and θ_0); the error without re-estimation is also included, so that $e_{\text{fit}} \le e_{\text{rel}}$. Scenarios whose output change is below $\max(10^{-10}\|y(\theta_0)\|, 10^{-6})$ are discarded. S is admissible if $|S| \ge k_{\min}$ and the median of e_{fit} over the scenarios is at most $\tau_e = \sqrt{1 - c^2}$. For each admissible subset we also report a level of guarantee: level 1 when only this condition holds, level 2 when in addition the median $\cos\Delta$ is at least c, and level 3 when in addition $R_{\text{var}}(S) \ge \tau_R$; these levels are reported, not required. For the eight problems in which the cost of simulation made repeated re-estimation impractical (marked in Table 1), the first-order version $\min_c \|\Delta y_{\text{full}} - J_{S\cup\Theta_C} c\| / \|\Delta y_{\text{full}}\|$ was used. This equals the minimum relative error attainable if the model response were exactly linear in parameter changes; for a truly linear model it equals the exact e_{fit}, while for nonlinear models it is an approximation (exact to second order) that replaces per-scenario optimisation with a single projection. The admissibility decision for these eight models is therefore made by linear algebra alone. The columns of J for the calibration parameters are computed together with those of the biological parameters, because the first-order re-estimation uses $J_{S\cup\Theta_C}$.

Settings

Unless stated otherwise: $\delta = 0.01$; $\eta = 0.1$; $\tau_R = 0.89$; $\tau_\kappa = \tau_{\text{VIF}} = 10$; $N = 15$ scenarios; $\varepsilon = 0.05$; random seed 42; $c = 0.9$, so $\tau_e = 0.436$; $k_{\min} = 2$. The sensitivity analysis (Supplementary Note *Sensitivity to the method settings*) changed one setting at a time on the 26 problems that could be re-run completely in reasonable time.

External validation

Measurements were split into training and test sets by experimental condition (every third condition after sorting, or the second of two conditions, used for testing) or, for problems with a single condition, by time (the last third of the distinct measurement times). Parameters that only affect test conditions were excluded from re-estimation. The reduced model (re-estimating $S \cup \Theta_C$) and the full model (re-estimating all parameters; not done for Lang, with 277 parameters and slow simulations, because it would require days to weeks of computation) were fitted to the training data from θ_0 with the same least-squares method and bounds, and evaluated by the mean squared noise-scaled residual $\chi^2/n = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i\in\text{test}}(y_i(\hat{\theta}) - \tilde{y}_i)^2$, where $\tilde{y}_i$ are the scaled measurements. In the synthetic experiment, the truth θ^* had each estimable parameter drawn uniformly within $\pm 20\%$ of θ_0 (parameters acting only in test conditions stayed at θ_0), data were simulated with Gaussian noise of standard

deviation σ_i, and $e_{\mathrm{pred}} = \|y_{\mathrm{test}}(\hat{\theta}) - y_{\mathrm{test}}(\theta^*)\| / \|y_{\mathrm{test}}(\theta^*) - y_{\mathrm{test}}(\theta_0)\|$; the effect of the parameter change was considered larger than the noise when χ^2/n of θ_0 on the synthetic test data was at least 2. The experiment was repeated with 20 seeds (42–61), each defining a different truth and noise realisation; the full model was not re-estimated for the four problems with more than 100 free parameters. Problems whose test χ^2/n at θ_0 was below 0.01 (Giordano, Perelson, Rahman) reproduce the data to far below the recorded noise level and are not shown in Fig. 3a. Test errors were compared through the ratio of the reduced to the reference χ^2/n; ratios between 0.95 and 1.05 were considered equivalent. For the leakage-free nested validation (Supplementary Note *Leakage-free nested validation*), the full model was first re-estimated on the training data (yielding $\hat{\theta}_{\mathrm{train}}$), and the reduced model was then re-estimated with the non-selected parameters fixed at $\hat{\theta}_{\mathrm{train}}$ and search bounds derived from $\hat{\theta}_{\mathrm{train}}$, for 29 problems (Bertozzi, Blasi and Lang excluded; for Chen the columns of the finite-difference Jacobian were evaluated in parallel and the integrator tolerances were $10^{-6}/10^{-8}$).

Comparison with other selection criteria

Each criterion selected the same number $k = |S|$ of biological parameters as our method, from the training data, and the calibration parameters of the problem were always added. *Pivoted QR*: column-pivoted QR decomposition of the sensitivity matrix of the training outputs at θ_0 with columns normalised to unit length[32]; the first k pivots. *Brun*: dimensionless sensitivities $\theta_j\, \partial y_i/\partial\theta_j$ on the training outputs, importance δ_j^{msqr}, and among the 15 most important parameters the k-subset with collinearity index $\gamma \le 10$ and the largest determinant measure ρ (the smallest γ if none satisfies the bound)[14]. *Morris*: ten trajectories (seed 42) on a four-level grid of $\log|\theta_j|$ within $[\theta_0/10,\, 10\theta_0]$, elementary effects measured by the norm of the change of the training outputs, and the k parameters with the largest μ^*[12]. *Profile likelihood*[5, 29]: the full model was first re-estimated on the training data; each biological parameter was then fixed at five values on each side of the optimum (up to a factor of 10, within the same bounds as all other fits) and all other parameters were re-estimated; whenever a point of a profile improved the optimum by more than one unit of χ^2, the full model was re-estimated from that point and the profiles were repeated (at most three times; ten for Raia). A parameter was classified as identifiable when its profile exceeded $\Delta\chi^2 = 3.84$ (95%, one degree of freedom) on both sides, and the k parameters with the narrowest confidence intervals were selected; this was feasible for the 26 problems with at most 60 free parameters. The *calibration-only* baseline re-estimated Θ_C alone, and the *random* baseline used the median test χ^2/n over 20 random k-subsets. Every subset was then evaluated with the external validation described above, with the admissibility test of our method (the same 15 scenarios and the same rules, at $\pm5\%$ and at $\pm20\%$) and with the synthetic experiment (20 seeds). The computation time of the complete method was measured by running it from scratch, without cached results, with the sensitivity computations distributed over 16–64 cores; all timings were obtained on a 128-core server shared with other computations and are therefore upper bounds.

Statistics

Comparisons between criteria were made over problems. For real data and for the synthetic prediction error, the statistic of each problem was the logarithm of the ratio of the errors of two criteria (for synthetic data, its median over seeds) and the two-sided Wilcoxon signed-rank test was applied. For the fraction of synthetic cases reaching $e_{\mathrm{pred}} \leq \tau_e$, 95% confidence intervals of the difference between two criteria were obtained by resampling whole problems, with all their seeds, 10,000 times (seed 0), so that seeds of the same problem are not treated as independent. Admissibility, one outcome per problem, was compared with the exact McNemar test on the problems in which only one of the two subsets was admissible.

Robustness patterns

For each admissible problem, the final subset was kept fixed and e_{fit} was evaluated at perturbation sizes $\varepsilon \in \{0.01, 0.05, 0.10, 0.20, 0.30, 0.40, 0.50\}$ with 15 scenarios per level. The fifteen directions $u^{(k)} \in [-1, 1]^p$, with independent uniform components, are drawn once per problem with a fixed seed (42) and reused at every level, $\theta^{(k)} = \theta_0 \odot (1 + \varepsilon u^{(k)})$; the directions are stored with the results. Patterns were assigned from the median e_{fit} at each level as described in Results; the pass rate is the fraction of valid scenarios with $e_{\mathrm{fit}} \leq \tau_e$. As in the selection, e_{fit} was computed to first order for the problems marked in Table 1. For Chen, between 8 and 13 of the 15 scenarios per level could be simulated; the remaining scenarios failed to integrate and were discarded.

Formal verification

The formal development uses Lean 4 (version 4.23.0) and Mathlib[19, 20] and has two parts (Fig. 6). The first proves, for any model that satisfies stated hypotheses, the mathematical results on which each step of the method relies (Supplementary Table S3, steps 1–22). The second establishes those hypotheses for concrete benchmark models. For this, each PEtab problem was translated automatically into a Lean file (`lean_translation/sbml_to_lean.py` of the reproducibility package): the rate laws and stoichiometry of the SBML model and the nominal parameter values and initial conditions of the PEtab tables are written as Lean expressions in which every number is an exact rational. Verified checkers, Boolean functions proved sound in Lean, then test that every rate law is defined and smooth on a domain containing the trajectory, that concentrations cannot become negative (quasi-positivity) and that the growth of the vector field is bounded so that the solution exists on the simulated horizon (linear growth, or a Riccati bound on a finite horizon for Crauste). The checkers are evaluated by the Lean kernel itself (`decide +kernel`), so their results are part of the proof, and each model ends with a theorem stating that it is smooth, that its solution exists and remains non-negative on the horizon, and that the solution is differentiable with respect to the parameters, which are the hypotheses of steps 14–22. This was achieved for 28 benchmark models (27 of the 34 problems analysed, and Froehlich); the reasons why the other seven problems were not verified are given in Supplementary Note *Verified benchmark*

models. Because the theorems are only as relevant as the translation is faithful, the translated vector fields, parameter values and initial values were compared independently with the SBML models evaluated by libRoadRunner at the nominal state and at five random states; they agree to rounding error (largest relative difference 10^{-12}), and changing a single number of a Lean file by 1% is detected. All files compile without `sorry`, and `#print axioms` reports only the standard axioms of Lean's logic (`propext`, `Classical.choice`, `Quot.sound`). The numerical analyses of this paper (J, R_{var}, κ, VIF, $\cos\Delta$, e_{fit} and the validation) were carried out in Python in double precision; a formal conclusion applies to a numerical result when the model's hypotheses are verified in Lean and the computed quantities satisfy the inequalities that the corresponding theorem requires (Supplementary Table S4).

Use of large language models

An AI assistant (Claude, Anthropic) was used to help write and debug analysis code and Lean proofs and to edit the manuscript text. All code, proofs and results were checked by the authors, who take full responsibility for the content.

Data availability. The PEtab benchmark problems analysed in this study are publicly available in the Benchmark-Models-PEtab collection (https://github.com/Benchmarking-Initiative/Benchmark-Models-PEtab, commit `fcbddf1`). All results generated in this study (selected subsets, external validation, synthetic prediction experiments, comparison with other selection criteria including the profile likelihoods, robustness, single-parameter subsets, sensitivity to the method settings, simulator check, computation times and the checks of the Lean models), one file per benchmark problem with a data dictionary, are included in the reproducibility package archived on Zenodo (doi:10.5281/zenodo.23338175) and in the folder `reproducibility/` of https://github.com/monicammr/archivos. The participant's step-count data of the social cognitive theory model are available from the corresponding author on reasonable request.

Code availability. The reproducibility package (Zenodo, doi:10.5281/zenodo.23338175; folder `reproducibility/` of https://github.com/monicammr/archivos) contains the Python code of the method and of every analysis, the programs that produce every figure and table of the paper from the stored results, the translator of the SBML models into Lean, and all Lean 4 proofs (folder `lean_proofs/`, a self-contained project that compiles with a single command, `./verify.sh`, and checks that no proof uses `sorry` or additional axioms). Its manual (`README.md`) describes three levels of checking: regenerating the figures and tables from the stored results, compiling the proofs, and re-running the analyses from the PEtab problems; Supplementary Note *Reproducibility package* summarises them.

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Author contributions. M.M.R. and C.S. conceived the study and designed the method. M.M.R. wrote the software and the formal proofs, performed the analyses and wrote the first draft. C.S., C.M. and A.A. supervised the work, contributed to

the validation of the results and revised the manuscript. All authors reviewed and approved the final manuscript.

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Ethics declarations. Ethics approval and consent to participate: The step-count data used for the social cognitive theory model were collected in a previously published study[17] approved by the Institutional Review Board of that study. The participant provided written informed consent for the use of their anonymised data in subsequent analyses.
Consent for publication: The participant whose data underlie the social cognitive theory analysis gave consent for publication of anonymised results.

Additional information. Competing interests: The authors declare no competing interests.
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Supplementary information accompanies this paper (Supplementary Notes, Tables and Figures); Supplementary Note *Concluding remarks* summarises its contents.

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